

OBESITY TREATMENTS
TREND, NECESSITY OR OVERREACH?



Photograph by BANDEEP SINGH

> **Prevention is far easier than curing obesity. So, act sensibly when you eat, what you eat, what you actually do as an exercise. And also, when you need, please visit your doctor; treatment is far easier now**
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> Semaglutide (marketed as Ozempic) has **undergone extensive clinical research**. [Regulatory] bodies have carefully evaluated the entire data.... Only when the benefit outweighs the risk, a medicine comes [into the market]

VIKRANT SHROTRIYA
Corporate Vice President & Managing Director, Novo Nordisk India

THE ABC OF WEIGHT LOSS

Medical research increasingly recognises obesity as more than just a cosmetic issue. Many governments, including India, now classify it as a disease—a metabolic abnormality marked by excess fat. Obesity is linked to 229 health conditions, including diabetes, hypertension, osteoarthritis, infertility and mental health disorders like depression and anxiety. However, combating obesity isn't just about willpower. According to Vikrant Shrotriya of Novo Nordisk India, who spoke on obesity treatments at the India Today Conclave, genetic and metabolic factors predispose individuals to consume more calories than needed. While food availability may have increased, human bodies remain wired to store fat for survival.

With the rise of weight-loss drugs like Ozempic, which Novo Nordisk markets as a medication for type 2 diabetes, many see them as a 'magic pill' for obesity. But Shrotriya busts this myth: "This is not a magic pill. This is not an excuse that I can party and take an injection [later]. This is a medicine for those who can't change their weight despite diet and exercise."

But effective weight loss requires a multifaceted approach that goes beyond medication. Shrotriya refers to it as "ABC—Attitude, Behaviour and Choices". The benefits are substantial. According to Shrotriya, even a 5 per cent reduction improves glycemic control and lowers blood pressure. At 10 per cent, the risk of type 2 diabetes and fatty liver decreases, and with 10-15 per cent loss, some may experience diabetes remission. A combination of medication, mindful eating, regular exercise and medical guidance can, thus, significantly enhance the quality of life. ■

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- **Obesity causes metabolic abnormality in the body. It needs to be understood from a biological point of view rather than in a cosmetic sense**
- **Medicine is not a magic cure for obesity. It needs to be taken alongside healthy lifestyle choices such as mindful eating and regular exercise**